CÉSAR VALLEJO

THE BLACK HERALDS

LOS HERALDOS NEGROS

TRANSLATED BY BARRY FOGDEN

THE BLACK HERALDS, César Vallejo's first book of poems, appeared in 1919. It clearly has late-Romantic and late-*modernista* roots, but, as D. Gallagher says in his survey *Modern Latin American Literature*, "what is remarkable about *Los heraldos negros* is the sense one gets now and then of a personal voice emerging. In many of the poems, Vallejo's own experiences, his own personality, begin confidently to express themselves, and with them there tentatively burgeons a new language, the beginnings of maybe the most original voice in Latin American poetry".

THIS NEW, complete translation of *Los heraldos negros*, by the poet Barry Fogden, is the result of extensive research into Vallejo's text, and its cultural, linguistic and poetic background. The translation is accurate and imaginative; it brings into the English language both the poetry and the poetics of the Peruvian original.

ALLARDYCE, BARNETT, PUBLISHERS

ISBN 0 907954 23 5

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1995

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A·B

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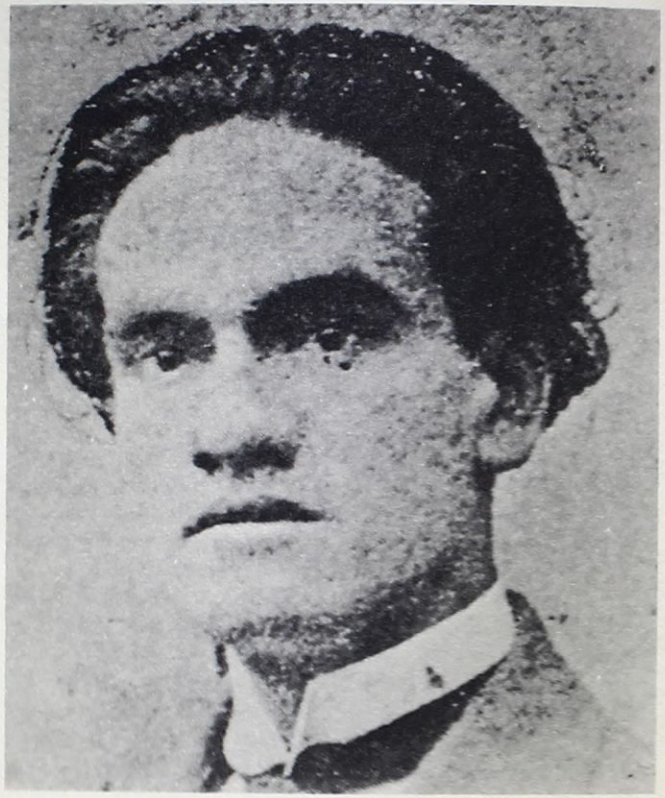

César Vallejo, c.1910

César Vallejo

THE BLACK HERALDS

– LOS HERALDOS NEGROS –

Translated from the Spanish by

BARRY FOGDEN

A·B

RW
2/26/96

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English translation of
Los heraldos negros by César A. Vallejo
Imp. Souza Ferreyra, Lima, 1918 [July 1919]

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First published in 1995 by
ALLARDYCE, BARNETT, PUBLISHERS
14 Mount Street, Lewes, East Sussex BN7 1HL
England

Distributed in the USA by
SPD INC
1814 San Pablo Avenue, Berkeley, CA 94709

A CIP record for this book is available from
The British Library and The Library of Congress

ISBN 0 907954 23 5

Printed by Whitstable Litho Printers Ltd, Kent

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

The chief text from which I have worked is the splendid edition of the *Obra poética* co-ordinated by Américo Ferrari (Colección Archivos, Nanterre, 1988); I have also referred to a facsimile of the first edition, and to two editions of *Obra poética completa* (Moncloa, Lima, 1968, and Biblioteca Ayacucho, Caracas, 1985). I have read what I believe to be the only other complete English translation of *Los heraldos negros* by Richard Schaaf and Kathleen Ross (Latin American Literary Review Press, Pittsburgh, 1990), and various versions of individual poems or groups of poems in the following books: *Modern Poetry from Spain and Latin America,* by Nan Braymer and Lillian Lowenfels (Corinth Books, New York, 1964), *Twenty Poems of César Vallejo,* by John Knoepfle, James Wright and Robert Bly (The Sixties Press, Madison MN, 1962), *César Vallejo: Selected Poems,* by H. R. Hays (Sachem Press, Old Chatham NY, 1981), *César Vallejo: Selected Poems,* by Ed Dorn and Gordon Brotherston (Penguin Books, Harmondsworth, 1976) and *César Vallejo: A Selection of his Poetry,* by James Higgins (Francis Cairns, Liverpool, 1987).

The critical, exegetical and other supporting material has been too extensive to catalogue here, but I would single out the writings of Juan Larrea, Alberto Escobar, and Clayton Eshleman. Eshleman's example over more than thirty years of devotion to Vallejo and his work has been inspirational to all anglophone Vallejo scholars. Two often cited full-length studies, *César Vallejo: The Dialectics of Poetry and Silence* by Jean Franco (Cambridge University Press, 1976) and *Poetología y escritura: Las crónicas de César Vallejo* by Enrique Ballón Aguirre (UNAM, México D. F., 1985) have been closely read, and have yielded many stimulating ideas.

My access to some very hard-to-come-by material has been greatly assisted by Simon Bowles, whose painstaking librarianship has unearthed several treasures, and by Alfonso Vijil of Redlands, California, book-sleuth extraordinary. I thank them both.

I would like to record my especial thanks to some of the people who have helped me during the preparation of this translation. Firstly, to Anthony Barnett, my editor: through long hours of discussion, sometimes hilarious, sometimes grave, he fought to keep me to the point and tame some of my wilder excesses, while encouraging defensible risk-taking. Also to the poets Paul Donnelly and Janet Holmes, who read the poems in draft form and made helpful comments, and to Enrique Solano of the Pontificia Universidad Católica del Perú in Lima for his enthusiastic and uniquely informed advice. Above all, I owe a debt of gratitude beyond words to my wife Celia, who sweetly tolerated me through the times when my mind was clearly somewhere in the *sierra*.

Barry Fogden

Qui potest capere capiat

–The Gospel

THE BLACK HERALDS

YOU get knocks in life, so vicious . . . It beats me!
Blows as if from God's hate; as if under their rain,
the backwash of everything you've suffered
stagnates in your soul . . . It beats me!

Not many; but you get them . . . They open up dark sluices
in the fiercest face and in the strongest back.
Perhaps they're the mounts of barbarian Attilas;
or the black heralds sent to us by Death.

They're the falls to earth of the Christs of your soul,
of some worshipful faith that Destiny blasphemes.
Those bleeding blows are the crackings
of a loaf burning away on us in the oven door.

And man . . . Wretched . . . wretched! He looks round,
as you do when a clap on the shoulder gets your attention;
he turns his mad eyes, and all the life he has lived
puddles, like a pool of guilt, in his gaze.

You get knocks in life, so vicious . . . It beats me!